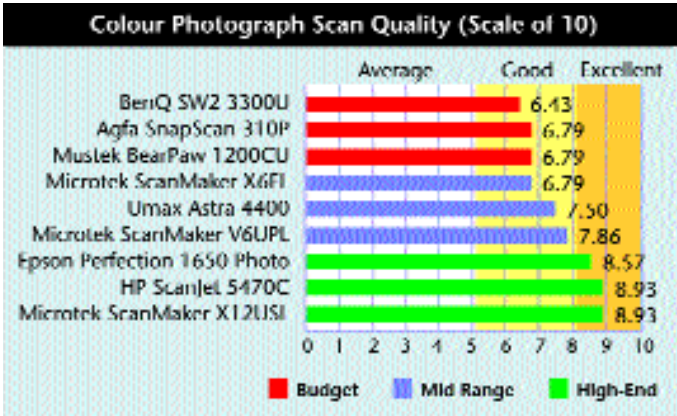




a rated colour scan depth of 30 bits and a greyscale scan depth of 10 bits, but it beats scanners rated at 48 bits!

In the mid range segment, the Microtek ScanMaker V6UPL scored an amazing 7.86 followed closely by the Umax Astra 4400, which scored a nifty 7.50. The Umax Astra 4400 unlike its sibling, the Umax Astra 5400, has consistently shown better performance—it's a little slow in scanning speeds, but is up there with the best when it comes to scan quality.

Scores of 8 out of 10 were quite common in the high-end segment with crisp reproduction of colours, sharp rendition of edges and excellent contrast. The HP ScanJet 5470C and Microtek X12USL scored an impressive 8.93 each—the scanned images were so beautiful that the original photograph itself looked a bit jaded. A complete surprise here was the Epson Perfection 1650. So far, its performance ranged between average to decent, but in this test it scores a brilliant 8.57.

Resolution test: When comparing the listed resolutions, always consider the smaller number, which denotes the optical resolution. If you need to pick up fine details, small fonts or complex lines and fine edges, you will need more optical resolution. The number of pixels a scanner can generate is based on how many CCDs are arranged horizontally and vertically in the scan head. Resolution is quoted both horizontally and vertically (for example, 300x600 denotes 300 pixels horizontally and 600 vertically).

All of this is theory. In practice, the ability of a scanner to actually capture as much data as possible depends on a variety of factors. A score of 3 out of 5 is acceptable here.

The budget scanners scored pretty decently in this test, with almost all of them scoring 3 out of 5. Most of them listed a resolution of 600x1200 dpi and were able to catch the finer details. Even the Agfa SnapScan 310P, which has a pretty low listed optical resolution of 300x600, scored a decent 3 points. The scanners that failed to impress here were the Microtek ScanMaker 3630 and the Umax AstraSlim 600, both scoring 2 points, even though they support a decent optical resolution of 600x1200.

Only two scanners in the mid range segment had support for optical resolutions higher than 600x1200. The Umax Astra 4400 and the 5400 support an impressive optical resolution of 1200x2400 and 1200x1200, respectively. This higher resolution directly translated into an impressive scan of the resolution bars—both detected four of the five bars in this test. Amongst the scanners with a rated resolution of 600x1200, only the Agfa SnapScan 1212P could manage 4 points; the rest were stuck at 3.

Among the high-end scanners, the HP ScanJet 5400C and 5470C had a very high rated resolution of 2400x2400. We expect-

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